WORKSHOP · HANDS-ON · 90 MINUTES · INTERMEDIATE

Workshop requirements

Everything to have in place before The Only Variable starts: what to know, what to install, and how to check your laptop in about two minutes.

IAN JOHNSON · https://github.com/tacoda/charter-workshop

In this workshop you take an application nobody in the room wrote, wrap it in an agent charter one lever at a time, and measure what each lever bought. You give the same ticket to a coding agent several times and score every run against the same nine checks. Most of the session is hands-on at your own keyboard, so arrive with the setup below already done.

01 Who it's for

This is an **intermediate** session. You'll get the most out of it if the items below already describe you.

AGENT USE	You use an AI coding agent (Claude Code, Cursor, Codex, Aider or similar) in your day-to-day work and have given it real tasks in a real repository.
TERMINAL	You're comfortable in a terminal: cloning a repo, running `make` targets and reading the output.
PYTHON	You can read Python. The sample application is Python, but you won't need to write much of it yourself.
GIT	You can read a diff and know your way around basic git.

You don't need any earlier experience writing a `CLAUDE.md`, rules files, hooks or MCP configuration. Building those is what the workshop covers.

02 What to bring

A laptop with three things on it.

PYTHON 3.11+	**Required.** This is the only hard dependency. Check with `python3 --version`.
GIT	**Required**, so you can clone the repository.
CODING AGENT	**Required.** Bring the agent you already use, signed in and working. The workshop page uses Claude Code's file paths (`CLAUDE.md`, `.claude/`) because it has to pick one tool, but every idea carries over and the facilitator points out the differences for Cursor and Codex.

You don't need any API keys beyond the ones your agent already uses, Docker, a database or network access during the session.

03 Set up before you arrive

About two minutes. Nothing downloads during the workshop, so do this at home or on a network you trust, not on conference wifi.

Clone the repository and run the doctor.

SHELL

```
git clone https://github.com/tacoda/charter-workshop.git
cd charter-workshop
make doctor
```

The doctor checks your Python version, the repository, the charter gate, the test suite, the seed data and whether a coding agent is on your `PATH`. A healthy machine looks like this:

MAKE DOCTOR — READY

```
  ok   python 3.12
  ok   git repository
  ok   pytest
 note  ruff     falls back to a bundled style check
 note  mypy     skipped when absent
  ok   charter gate
  ok   test suite
  ok   seed data     seeded
  ok   coding agent

  ready. `make ticket TICKET=TAR-412` prints the first task.
```

ok	That check passed.
note	Not a problem. `ruff` and `mypy` are optional, and every `make` target falls back to a bundled standard-library equivalent.
fail	Something is blocking. Fix it before the day if you can. If you can't, take it to a facilitator in the first five minutes.

Confirm that your agent works in this directory. Open it in `charter-workshop/` and ask it something simple about the repository. If it can read the files, you're set.

Optional: install the full toolchain. This puts `pytest`, `ruff` and `mypy` in a local virtual environment. Everything works without it.

SHELL · OPTIONAL

```
make setup
source .venv/bin/activate
```

04 If your laptop fails anyway

You can still follow the whole workshop.

The repository ships five captured reference runs in `runs/reference/`. This command prints the full results matrix from them without calling a model:

```shell
make reference
```

You'll be reading results instead of producing your own, which is worse, but you can still follow every step.

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05 On the day

The checklist for walking in.

[ ]	Repository cloned from `github.com/tacoda/charter-workshop`
[ ]	`make doctor` ends with `ready.`
[ ]	Coding agent signed in and working in the repo directory
[ ]	Laptop charged, with a charger in your bag
[ ]	`workshop/index.html` opens in your browser. It's the page you'll follow along with, and it has every code sample shown on screen.